

Chapter 20: New Life

Yan Lin's process of compromise was unexpected to Feng Yue, but the result was exactly what Feng Yue had anticipated.

But when she saw the divorce agreement signed with both their names, Feng Yue still felt a sense of sudden realization.

This twelve-year-long mistaken relationship that spanned two lifetimes had finally been set right today, in this small private restaurant.

This outcome was completely unexpected to the four elders, but seeing the two children - one looking dazed and the other expressionless - they couldn't bring themselves to say anything harsh.

Yan Lin silently stood up, nodded slightly to the elders, then left the private room without looking back.

Lady Yan looked at Feng Yue, then at Yan Lin's retreating figure, and had no choice but to chase after her with Mr. Yan. Before leaving, she told Feng Yue: "Sweetheart, regarding hospitals and doctors, just contact Mom if you need anything." She paused here, then sighed and left as well.

The Yan family hurriedly departed. Feng Yue, watching the scene she had long anticipated, pressed her lips together and said to her parents: "Mom, Dad, let's eat. The Cantonese cuisine here is really quite good."

The two parents looked at each other, not knowing what to say for a moment. Under normal circumstances, they would definitely get to the bottom of the divorce matter, but when divorce and brain cancer were put together, the former seemed less important.

"Nuan Nuan, Mom won't ask too many questions about you and A-Lin. You're an adult now, and you have your own considerations about your affairs. Your father and I shouldn't interfere." Lady Feng paused. "But about your illness, can you talk to Mom properly about it? Or should we go to the hospital for another examination tomorrow?"

"Yes, Dad has a friend who's the director of the municipal hospital. Let's go to the hospital together tomorrow."

Feng Yue nodded: "Alright, then I'll go home and stay tonight, and we'll go to the hospital together tomorrow." Feng Yue knew this examination was unavoidable, and going to the hospital with her parents would also put their minds at ease.

Seeing Feng Yue nod, the two parents finally breathed a sigh of relief. They had experienced too much tonight and still hadn't quite recovered.

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On the other side, Yan Lin, who had practically fled from the room, didn't have such a harmonious situation as Feng Yue's family.

Mr. Yan and Lady Yan returned to the old mansion with Yan Lin, almost without speaking a word.

Seeing that their masters all looked grim, the servants very sensibly left one by one, leaving only the Yan family of three in the large mansion.

Yan Lin knew her parents had many questions, so she waited for them to speak.

Lady Yan looked at Yan Lin's stuffy demeanor and felt furious. She took a deep breath, barely suppressing her anger: "First tell me what's wrong with Feng Yue's illness!"

Yan Lin pressed her lips together, thought for a moment, then told her parents what she had learned from Wei Yuran. After learning about Feng Yue's condition, her contact with Wei Yuran had become frequent, though most of the time it was Wei Yuran reporting Feng Yue's situation to her.

After listening to her detailed explanation of Feng Yue's condition, Lady Yan finally let out the breath she'd been holding. Meanwhile, Mr. Yan remained silent with a stern face.

It wasn't until the mother and daughter had finished talking that Mr. Yan stood up with a severe expression and said to Yan Lin: "Come with me to the study."

Lady Yan was somewhat worried and wanted to stop them, but after thinking about it, she restrained herself. Her daughter did need some proper education.

In the study, Mr. Yan sat in the chair behind his desk while Yan Lin stood opposite like a child who had done something wrong, her head slightly lowered so her expression couldn't be seen clearly.

"A-Lin, how do you think of your own personality?" Mr. Yan suddenly asked after a long silence.

Yan Lin was somewhat stunned and didn't know how to answer her father's question for a moment.

Mr. Yan didn't wait for her answer and continued on his own: "Since childhood, you've shown maturity and steadiness beyond your peers. You never cried or made a fuss, and never asked the servants for help with things you could do yourself.

Your mother and I always thought you were very obedient and didn't cause worry. But as you gradually grew up, this quietness and maturity gradually evolved into a kind of aloof coldness and arrogance. You rarely communicated with people and never took anyone seriously, though they indeed weren't as excellent as you.

Your mother and I were always worried that your psychological condition might develop problems, but A-Yue's appearance dispelled our concerns.

Dad doesn't know what you think about this divorce, but I hope that even if you divorce, you won't give up on A-Yue.

Throughout the ten-plus years you've known each other, she's always been the one chasing after you, whether in high school, college, or after marriage. A-Yue has given too much for you. If you lose her just like this, I believe you'll live in regret for the rest of your life."

The study was very quiet, with the soothing scent of sandalwood¹ in the air.

Mr. Yan spoke slowly, but his words still pierced Yan Lin's heart like a dull knife.

In her previous life, her father had said similar things. Yan Lin remembered that it was when she hadn't seen Feng Yue for the last time, her father standing in the hospital corridor saying to her:

"A-Lin, you'll live in regret forever."

At that time, Yan Lin didn't know what deeper meaning this sentence had. Only now did she understand.

Her father had seen clearly from the beginning.

Between her and Feng Yue, it wasn't that Feng Yue couldn't live without her, but that she had long been unable to live without Feng Yue.

Yet such a simple truth, Yan Lin only understood now.

Yan Lin couldn't hear what her father said afterward.

Feng Yue had pulled her from an empty, deserted island into a world full of human warmth², yet she herself, relying on Feng Yue's love for her, had never given Feng Yue even half a response.

Feng Yue was right - everything she had previously possessed had nothing to do with Yan Lin. Going to the same high school and college as Yan Lin, dating and marrying Yan Lin - all of this was what Feng Yue had pursued herself, having nothing to do with Yan Lin.

So now, when Feng Yue wanted to cast Yan Lin aside, this also had nothing to do with Yan Lin.

Yan Lin had once thought she was the one in control of this relationship, but now it seemed the reins had always been firmly grasped in Feng Yue's hands.

She, Yan Lin, was nothing more than a dog in Feng Yue's hands - arrogant and condescending³.

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When Fu Sixue received Yan Lin's call, she was still drawing design sketches in her studio. So when she learned that Yan Lin was at Yanjing's most famous bar, she almost wondered if she had become too absorbed in her sketches.

But recalling that Yan Lin had previously mentioned divorce to her, she had a bad feeling, so she hung up the phone and quickly grabbed a coat to meet her.

As soon as Fu Sixue arrived at the bar, she was led by a server to Yan Lin's private room. The moment she opened the door, she was hit by the smell of alcohol.

Looking at the bottles scattered on the table and Yan Lin obviously having drunk quite a bit while leaning on the sofa, Fu Sixue thought her guess might be correct.

She dismissed the server behind her, then turned on the lights in the private room and silently sat next to Yan Lin.

Yan Lin leaned back against the sofa with her head tilted back, covering her eyes with the back of one hand: "The lights are a bit harsh."

Fu Sixue poured herself a drink and took a gulp. After the two remained silent for a while, she asked: "Divorced?"

"Mm." Yan Lin straightened up, her gaze falling on the bottles on the table, as if speaking to herself or to Fu Sixue: "She's sick and needs to maintain a good mindset for proper recovery. I don't want her to get angry or upset anymore."

Fu Sixue frowned. She hadn't known Feng Yue was ill before. What kind of illness could make Yan Lin compromise and sign divorce papers?

"What illness does she have? Is it serious?"

"Mm, early-stage brain cancer." Yan Lin's eyes were slightly red, her voice somewhat hoarse. "The kind that's serious enough to kill."

Feng Yue had left her because of this illness in her previous life.

"...Holy shit!" Fu Sixue tilted her head back and drank all the alcohol in her glass in one gulp.

"Damn, how much has Little Moon suffered all these years."

Fu Sixue had originally wanted to complain about all the inhuman things Yan Lin had done to Feng Yue over the years, but glancing at Yan Lin's current state, she suddenly couldn't say a word.

Silent torment was what Yan Lin was experiencing in her heart right now.

"I say," Fu Sixue put down her glass and looked at the dejected Yan Lin, "you're not just going to give up on Little Moon like this, are you?"

Yan Lin looked at her somewhat blankly, then instinctively shook her head.

"No, I won't give up."

"That's right. Little Moon has suffered so much all these years. It's about time you took the initiative to chase after her." Fu Sixue reached up to smooth the hair by her cheek. "You two are both single women now⁴. Pursuing someone - isn't this the perfect time?"

"All of this is what you owe her." Fu Sixue thought for a moment and continued: "But this time, don't put yourself in such a high position. You're not some lofty goddess⁵ now. You're just an ordinary suitor who wants what she can't have, one of many around Feng Yue."

"In fact, your impression score with Little Moon is different from other suitors - it's negative two hundred."

"I know." Yan Lin frowned again: "Other suitors?"

Fu Sixue raised an eyebrow with a slight smile: "Who knows? After all, our Little Moon is quite excellent."

"Alright, don't overthink it." Fu Sixue raised her glass and lightly clinked it with Yan Lin's: "Here's to your new life going smoothly."

Yan Lin looked at the alcohol in her glass and murmured: "New... life..."

Then she too tilted her head back and drank the contents of her glass in one gulp.

Footnotes:

¹ **Sandalwood (檀香):** A fragrant wood commonly burned as incense in Chinese culture, particularly in studies and meditation spaces, believed to have calming and focusing properties.

² **Human warmth/world full of smoke and fire (烟火人间):** A Chinese phrase referring to the warm, bustling world of human life and emotions, contrasting with cold isolation. "Smoke and fire" refers to cooking and daily life activities that make a place feel like home.

³ **Arrogant and condescending (目无下尘眼高于顶):** A Chinese idiom literally meaning "eyes that see no dust below and look above the top," describing someone extremely arrogant who looks down on everyone.

⁴ **Single women (女未婚女未嫁):** A play on the traditional phrase describing unmarried people. Fu Sixue is emphasizing that both are now free to pursue new relationships.

⁵ **Lofty goddess (高高在上的神女):** Refers to someone who acts superior and untouchable, like a deity who is above mortal concerns and relationships.